

**What is 'Curry'? A Discussion of the History and Popularization of Indian Cuisine within
Britain from the 1800s to the 2000s**

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Indian cuisine is one of the most recognizable cuisines with its abundant use of spices, all perfectly blended into a sauce and served with rice and naan bread. But there is more to Indian cuisine than what is seen being sold in supermarkets and diners for mass consumption. The Indian cuisine that is so well-known today is not traditional in the sense that it is often ‘watered down’ for all types of palates to enjoy. However, what is most unfortunate when it comes to Indian cuisine is the use of the word ‘curry’ to describe many Indian dishes, when in truth, the term ‘curry’ was invented by the British to describe spiced dishes from around the world, including those from British-ruled India. The production and consumption of the spice mix known as ‘curry powder’ is also tragic in the way that it does not stick to traditional uses of spices but devalues the importance of balance within Indian cookery. However, my aim is not to strictly discuss Indian cooking methods, but rather how the Anglo-Indian cuisine that is so well-known and popular within the present-day United Kingdom came to be by combining the knowledge acquired during my Culinary Arts schooling and my research skills as an undergraduate student. To do so, I will be focusing specifically on the period between the 1800s to the early 2000s and determining how the cultural arrogance of the British empire, cookbooks of the nineteenth century, societal exchanges of information, and the big boom of immigrant run ‘Indian’ restaurants after the second world war in postcolonial Britain affected the authenticity of Indian cuisine. For the sake of this essay, I will be referring to Indian-based meals as ‘curries’ and to the fusional cuisine of Indian and British food as ‘Anglo-Indian’, not because I deem these dishes to be called as such, but because this is how they are referenced by English-speakers within the sources.

According to the third edition of Linda Civitello’s *Cuisine and Culture*, “curry is an inaccurate catch-all term that was spread by the British, who did not differentiate among India’s

diverse regional cuisines”^[1] therefore making the term ‘curry’ a homogenizing term, and yet the actual origins of the word are unknown as there are many possible sources. For example, some say that the word came from the Tamil word *kari* which means ‘sauce’ or ‘relish for rice’, or that it may have been from the Kannada word for ‘vegetable’ (*tarakari*). As such, it is easy to see how the British would have deemed this to be the term used to describe the dishes they were served such as “broths, a wet stew, or a dry dish”^[2], their favourites being meat dishes stewed in spiced sauces and served with perfectly cooked rice, reminiscent of the meat, potatoes, and gravy the British were accustomed to. However, many of these dishes were completely transformed into an Anglo-Indian cuisine based off Mughal cuisine. Even though the British colonists realized that each region within South Asia had its own cuisine, they continued to lump dishes together under one word, therefore completely denying regional pride and individualism and demonstrating Britain’s insensitivity to other cultures and heritages.

The popularity of Indian spices began back in the 1700s when the spice trade was growing due to the British East India Company trade routes and the mass consumption by the British of anything ‘oriental’. Yet, Indian cuisine was not popular at first as British colonists described the cuisine as “pungent, chile-spiked curries and rice and *rotis* [which] were considered food for uncivilized pagans”^[3] and since the dishes were considered stews, they were deemed to be peasant food. Many of the colonists within India could also not handle the high levels of heat and as such Indian dishes made for Britons had “a basic formula: first spices, onion, and garlic were ground and bound together by ghee, then this paste was added to some meat, and simmered.”^[4] Although Indian spices were popular in the eighteenth century, it was not until 1773 that the Norris Street Coffee House became the first restaurant to put a curry on their menu for public consumption. It was also around this time that the British masses became

completely enamored by the Anglo-Indian cuisine, as the spices and flavours continued to be brought over by the East India Company's *nabobs*. Yet it was not until 1809 that the first Indian-owned restaurant, Hindoostane Coffee House, was opened in Britain in London's Portman Square by Sake Dean Mahomed^[5] although he had to sell his shop a year later due to increasing competition; the restaurant closed in 1833 as Indian cuisine had begun to lose its appeal in the mid-1800s due to a renewal of the domination of European dishes.^[6] Indian cuisine lost further popularity after the Indian Rebellion of 1857 to 1858, but all hope was not lost as the continued success of cookbooks from the early to mid-1800s unknowingly continued the endorsement of curries within British households by exploiting a new market: women.

In Susan Zlotnick's article "Domesticating Imperialism: Curry and Cookbooks in Victorian England", Zlotnick discusses how "the three most influential domestic cookery books written by and for the Victorian middle-class woman – the various reprints and revisions of Maria Rundell's 1807 *Domestic Cookery*, Eliza Acton's 1845 *Modern Cookery in all its Branches*, and Isabella Beeton's celebrated 1859 *Book of Household Management* – all contain chapters on curry."^[7] However, these recipes were anything but authentic as they did not follow the three stages of Indian cookery: warming the spices in oil to release aroma, creating a gravy base with vegetables and/or meat, and then allowing the mixture to simmer until fully cooked.^[8] Rather, these recipes, like the ones in Marie Rundell's *Domestic Cookery*, would take traditional British dishes like braised chicken and added curry powder to stock or to a sauce^[9], rather than to oil. The use of Indian recipes within households was further promoted by housewives competing on who had the most 'authentic' recipes, especially if those recipes came from an Indian chef. However, through a sort of print capitalism, they ended up further promoting the

misuse of spices and became a building-block for the ever-evolving national identity of British cuisine.

The use of curry powder was prominent in British households with curry powder being “sold as early as 1784 in London.[\[10\]](#)” Unbeknownst to many, curry powder is a British-made spice mixture consisting of cumin, chili, fenugreek, and large amounts of turmeric, and though it is recognizable as an ingredient in Indian cuisine by many Caucasian societies, and you will not find this product anywhere in India. Yet, this spice mixture grew in popularity and as noted by Zlotnick, “curry advertisements publicized and popularized the image of the British as indulgent, open-handed masters.”[\[11\]](#) Even though this mixture never lived up to its promise of delivering ‘authentic’ Indian cuisine, that did not stop the import of turmeric between 1820 to 1840 from tripling. Merchants in the 1840s were constantly persuading the public of the dietary benefits of curry, especially during the 1924-1925 British Empire Exhibition at Wembley where British import companies marketed their spices amongst the curries and *pillaos* (‘rice pilaf’) being served at the cafes[\[12\]](#). By the end of the 1800s “even nonspecialist grocers normally stocked three types of curry powder: a yellow, a brown, and a fiery, chilli-flavored red one.”[\[13\]](#) However, this was not the only product popularized by the Anglo-Indian cuisine, as reinvented versions of Mulligatawny soup, *pillaos*, and regional dishes began to gain notoriety.

Mulligatawny soup is a ‘curry’ soup containing spices, vegetables, and rice. Its name comes from Tamil words *molo tunny* meaning ‘peppery water’ and was said to have been created in Madras.[\[14\]](#) This soup eventually became so popular that tins of it started becoming canned and sold by the 1850s.[\[15\]](#) Mulligatawny soup also started appearing on menus of elite clubs and from there to the middle and lower classes[\[16\]](#) with some fans even going so far as to create curry clubs as discussed in the 1885 *Graphic* article accurately titled “Curry Clubs”. Within this

article, the author, known only as F.E.W., discusses his experience with a curry club in a small town in Britain where he was so awestruck by how delicious the food was that “when dining with no appetite on the monotonous “house” dinner of [his] club, [he was thinking] what a blessed relief the Indian *cuisine* would make to the eternal roasts and boiled of a British dinner.”[\[17\]](#) The author further promoted his case by discussing the economic benefits of ‘curries’ as they consist of only a pound of rice, some meat, and a sauce.[\[18\]](#)

The author states that within the 1880s, many people are still unaware of how much more Indian cuisine had to offer the Brits, than just the ever-bland curry powder:

“It is unquestionably the fact that not one Englishman in a hundred has ever tasted real curry; curry such as a Curry Club only can show. The curries one meets with at English dinner tables are all made with curry powder, preserved in bottles, and are flat and tasteless. There is as much difference between these and a real Indian curry as there is between a salmon fresh from the ocean, with the sea lice on him, and a worthless old kelt that has been months in the river.”[\[19\]](#)

However, the author notes that this cuisine “should not be mixed with any foreign school of cookery”[\[20\]](#) such as British cookery or French cookery because it will further mitigate the flavours with the author stating a need for simplification where these curry clubs “should confine [their] *cuisine* strictly to mulligatawny soup, curry, and *pillao*...and should import a good Indian cook to instruct other in his art”[\[21\]](#) therefore maintaining the cuisine’s integrity and ‘authenticity’. Although what someone in 1885 would know about ‘authentic’ Indian cuisine is questionable as it was not until the later twentieth century that questions began arising as to what could truly be defined as Indian cuisine. However, as Collingham states, “Is authenticity really

the right yardstick by which to judge an Indian meal?”[\[22\]](#) As the British were more concerned about what suited their palates, rather than the true traditional meals of India’s many regional cuisines.

It is not surprising that even back in 1885 there was obsession with Indian cuisine, especially when compared to British food fare that lacked the brightness and flavour that was so evidently present within Indian dishes. Yet, many Britons were still convinced that curry was “synonymous with Indian food,”[\[23\]](#) although thankfully most people are now aware that there are not many dishes within India “that are actually called ‘curry’ in any of the indigenous languages”[\[24\]](#) as Palat notes. Yet the concept of having ‘curry in a hurry’ became more attractive as the middle-class continued to grow. This concept continued to be promoted by the opening of ‘Indian-style’ restaurants during WWII and “by 1946, there were twenty Indian high-street restaurants in London and many more in working-class areas.”[\[25\]](#) However, it was not until the 1960s, after WWII, that immigrant-run restaurants began to gain the spotlight; before this the British had continued to maintain their conservative distance from restaurants that were run by ‘non-Brits’.[\[26\]](#) Surprisingly though, it was not Indian migrants who set up most of the ‘Indian’ restaurants, but rather Bangladeshi and Pakistani migrants.[\[27\]](#) And it was because of these ever-growing number of restaurants that curry and even chutney (chopped up fruits and vegetables with vinegar, sugar, and spices) “became mainstays of the British diet.”[\[28\]](#) Although I would go so far as to suggest that Anglo-Indian based curries and chutneys are an example of a physical form of the British empire’s continuing domination in the postcolonial era.

By the 1990s, the damage was already done, and the term ‘curry’ became a permanent fixture in British culture. More so, in 1997, “a Gallup poll announced that curry was the nation’s favourite food”[\[29\]](#) and by 2001, the debate of whether this fusion of British and Indian cuisine

historically belonged to Britain finally came to a head “when the foreign minister Robin Cook announced chicken tikka masala as the new national dish of Great Britain,”[\[30\]](#) saying that it was a true evocation of British multiculturalism. Unsurprisingly, this was met with much backlash with critics saying that chicken tikka masala was nothing more than “a British invention”[\[31\]](#) that was a sweetened and unappetizing Anglo-Indian dish that in no way indicated “British culture was open to outside influences – with *masala* being added to the Indian chicken *tikka* to cater to the British palate”[\[32\]](#) Rumour says that the dish was made on British soil by a Bangladeshi chef when a customer complained that the chicken was too dry so the chef added a can of “Campbell’s tomato soup, cream, and some spices to a chicken *tikka*”[\[33\]](#) with the masala sauce acting as a gravy. Most notably, Indian food is a large part of Britain’s economy where “Indian food accounted for almost two-thirds of all the money spent eating outside the home in Britain”[\[34\]](#) Indian food is also so popular that the UK has a ‘National Curry Week’ running from the second week of October to the third week of October every year in which all Brits are to celebrate the ‘love affair’ that is the UK’s obsession with all-things curry, and not just ‘going out for an Indian’ after a few pints[\[35\]](#) whenever the mood strikes.

Zlotnick states it well that “curry became so ‘completely naturalized’ ...[as it] began as an English fabrication of Indian food, was domesticated by the middle-class Victorian women in the first half of the nineteenth century and then commodified and returned to India as the gift of its ‘civilizer’ in the second half.”[\[36\]](#) Before this, Indian cuisine was losing its hold on the heartstrings of British stomachs across the empire, and it was not until after WWII that Indian restaurants began to open up at full tilt much to the British public’s delight. However, these restaurants, even to this day, are so reminiscent of the British empire’s arrogance that indigenous cuisines should cater to the ‘more refined’ British palate, yet it can also be said that these

restaurants are an indication of the reversal of the direction of influence[\[37\]](#) where the British are becoming more and more a “curry-eating race[\[38\]](#)” as unknowingly foreshadowed in 1885. Throughout the years, the adapted dishes known simply as ‘curries’ by the (oblivious) British public, while becoming every day ‘classics’, remain nothing more than part of the fusional Anglo-Indian cuisine of so long ago, and in a way, are one of the best examples of how aged colonial influences continue to prevail within a world of haphazardly forgotten histories.

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[1] Linda Civitello, *Cuisine and Culture: A History of Food and People Third Edition* (John Wiley & Sons, 2011), 267.

[2] Civitello, 273.

[3] Michael Nenes, *International Cuisine* (John Wiley & Sons, 2009), 574.

[4] Lizzie Collingham, *Curry: A Tale of Cooks and Conquerors* (Oxford University Press, 2007), 139, accessed 4 April 2021, <https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/ualberta/detail.action?docID=271277>.

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[7] Susan Zlotnick "Domesticating Imperialism: Curry and Cookbooks in Victorian England," *Frontiers: A Journal of Women Studies* 16, no. 2 (1996): 60, accessed 4 April 2021, doi: 10.2307/3346803.

[8] Nenes, 548.

[9] Maria Eliza Rundell, *Mrs. Rundell's Domestic Cookery*, (London: Routledge, Warnes, and Routledge, 1859), 75-76, accessed 4 April 2021, https://books.google.ca/books?redir_esc=y&id=gj8CAAAAQAAJ&q=currie#v=snippet&q=currie&f=false

[10] Illaria Porciani, *Food Heritage and Nationalism in Europe* (London: Routledge, 2019), 20, accessed 4 April 2021, doi: 10.4324/9780429279751.

[11] Zlotnick, 64.

[12] Collingham, 153.

[13] Collingham, 141.

[14] Collingham, 120.

[15] Palat, 176.

[16] Jeffrey Pilcher, *Food in World History 2nd Edition* (Taylor & Francis, 2017), 82.

[17] F. E. W., "Curry Clubs," *The Graphic* 31, no. 796 (February 28, 1885): 219, accessed 4 April 2021,

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[18] W., 219.

[19] W., 219.

[20] W., 219.

[21] W., 219.

[22] Collingham, 2.

[23] Collingham, 24.

[24] Palat, 174.

[25] Palat, 177.

[26] Porciani, 20.

[27] Palat, 175.

[28] Pilcher, 61.

[29] Porciani, 13.

[30] Collingham, 2.

[31] Collingham, 2.

[32] Palat, 172.

[33] Palat, 172.

[34] Palat, 172.

[35] Palat, 178.

[36] Zlotnick, 64.

[37] Pilcher, 80.

[38] W., 219.